

Markdown Cheat Sheet

26 tables · 141 concepts · Updated 2026-04-28 · cheatgrid.com

Markdown is a **lightweight markup language** created by John Gruber in 2004 for writing formatted text using plain-text editors. It's designed to be **easy to read and write**, converting seamlessly to HTML while remaining human-readable in its raw form. Markdown has become the de facto standard for documentation, README files, note-taking apps, static site generators, and content management systems. The **CommonMark specification** standardizes Markdown syntax, while **GitHub Flavored Markdown (GFM)** extends it with tables, task lists, strikethrough, alerts, math expressions, and Mermaid diagrams — features now widely adopted across development platforms.

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TABLE 1

Headings

Headings give a document its structure, and Markdown offers two ways to write them. The hash-prefix ATX style (`#` through `#####`) is by far the most common and covers all six levels, while the older Setext style underlines text for the top two. Custom IDs let you link straight to a specific section.

Syntax	Example	Description
ATX headings	<pre># Heading 1 ## Heading 2 ### Heading 3</pre>	- Use 1–6 hash symbols <code>#</code> followed by a space - number of hashes determines heading level (H1–H6).
Setext headings	<pre>Heading 1 ===== Heading 2 -----</pre>	- Underline text with <code>=</code> for H1 or <code>-</code> for H2 - alternative syntax for top two levels only.
Heading IDs	<pre>### My Heading {#custom-id}</pre>	- Add custom anchor ID using <code>{#id}</code> syntax - enables linking directly to specific sections.

TABLE 2

Text Emphasis

The everyday formatting that makes prose readable — bold, italic, and their combination, all built from asterisks or underscores. A handful of these go beyond core Markdown: strikethrough is a GFM extension, while highlight, subscript, and superscript usually rely on extended syntax or a fall-back to raw HTML tags.

Technique	Example	Description
Bold	<pre>**bold text** or __bold text__</pre>	Wrap text in double asterisks <code>**</code> or double underscores <code>__</code> for strong emphasis .
Italic	<pre><i>*italic text*</i> or <i>_italic text_</i></pre>	Wrap text in single asterisks <code>*</code> or single underscores <code>_</code> for emphasis .
Bold and italic	<pre>***bold italic*** or ___bold italic___</pre>	Use triple asterisks <code>***</code> or triple underscores <code>___</code> for combined emphasis .
Strikethrough	<pre>~~strikethrough~~</pre>	- Wrap text in double tildes <code>~~</code> to display crossed-out text - GFM extension.
Underline	<pre><ins>underlined text</ins></pre>	- Use HTML <code><ins></code> tag for underlined text - no native Markdown syntax exists for underline.
Highlight	<pre>==highlighted text==</pre>	- Wrap text in double equals signs <code>==</code> to mark/highlight - extended syntax, not universally supported.
Subscript	<pre>H~2~0 or H<sub>2</sub>0</pre>	Use single tildes <code>~</code> or HTML <code><sub></code> tags for subscript text.
Superscript	<pre>X^2^ or X<sup>2</sup></pre>	Use single carets <code>^</code> or HTML <code><sup></code> tags for superscript text.

TABLE 3

Paragraphs and Line Breaks

One of Markdown's most common surprises is that pressing Enter doesn't always create a new line — paragraphs are separated by blank lines, and a line break *within* a paragraph needs explicit help. These options show the three ways to force that break: trailing spaces, a backslash, or an HTML `<br>` tag.

Element	Example	Description
Paragraph	<pre>First paragraph. Second paragraph.</pre>	- Separate paragraphs with a blank line - consecutive lines without blank lines merge into one paragraph.

Element	Example	Description
Hard line break	First line Second line	End a line with two or more spaces then press Enter to force a line break within a paragraph.
Line break with backslash	First line`  Second line   • End a line with a <b>**backslash**</b> ` to create a hard line break • more visible alternative to trailing spaces	
HTML break tag	First line Second line	Insert <code>
</code> HTML tag for explicit line breaks ; works when HTML is supported.

TABLE 4

Lists

From simple bullets to nested hierarchies and GitHub's interactive checkboxes, lists are everywhere in Markdown. The detail that trips people up most is indentation — sub-items and continuation paragraphs need 4 spaces or a tab to stay attached to their parent item.

Type	Example	Description
Unordered list	- Item 1 - Item 2 - Item 3	• Start lines with <code>-</code> , <code>*</code> , or <code>+</code> followed by a space • use consistent markers within a list.
Ordered list	1. First 2. Second 3. Third	• Start lines with a number, period <code>.</code> or <code>)</code> , and a space • numbering auto-corrects in rendered output.
Nested list	1. Item - Sub-item - Sub-item	• Indent sub-items by 4 spaces or 1 tab to create nested lists • mix ordered and unordered.
Task list	- [] Unchecked - [x] Checked	• Use <code>- []</code> for unchecked and <code>- [x]</code> for checked checkboxes • GFM extension; interactive on GitHub issues and PRs.
Multi-paragraph list items	1. First paragraph. Second paragraph.	Indent continuation paragraphs by 4 spaces or 1 tab to keep them within the same list item.

TABLE 5

Links

Links come in more flavors than most people realize. Inline links are the workhorse, but reference-style links keep dense text readable by moving URLs out of the way, relative links keep repository docs portable across branches and forks, and autolinks turn a bare URL into a clickable one automatically.

Technique	Example	Description
Inline link	[Link text](https://example.com)	• Wrap text in <code>[]</code> and URL in <code>()</code> • most common link syntax .
Link with title	[Link](https://example.com "Title")	• Add optional title attribute in quotes after URL • shows on hover.
Reference-style link	[Link][ref] [ref]: https://example.com	• Define link reference separately • keeps text clean and readable .
Relative link	[Contributing](docs/CONTRIBUTING.md)	• Link to files relative to the current file • preferred over absolute links inside repositories.
Autolink	<https://example.com>	Wrap URL or email in <code><></code> to create automatic clickable link .
Autolink literals	https://example.com	GFM automatically converts bare URLs to clickable links without angle brackets.
Email link	<email@example.com>	Wrap email address in <code><></code> to create mailto link .

Technique	Example	Description
Anchor link	<code>[Link] (#heading-id)</code>	• Link to headings using <code>#</code> followed by auto-generated or custom ID • creates internal page navigation.

TABLE 6
Images

Image syntax mirrors link syntax with a leading `!`, and the same reference-style and relative-path tricks apply. Two practical notes stand out: always write meaningful alt text for accessibility, and because Markdown can't resize images, reach for a raw `<img>` tag when you need to control width.

Technique	Example	Description
Inline image	<code>![Alt text](image.jpg)</code>	• Use <code>!</code> before link syntax • alt text describes image for accessibility and appears if image fails.
Image with title	<code>![Alt](image.jpg "Title")</code>	• Add optional title attribute in quotes • displays as tooltip on hover.
Reference-style image	<code>![Alt][img-ref]</code> <code>[img-ref]: image.jpg</code>	Define image reference separately for reusability and cleaner text .
Linked image	<code>[![Alt](image.jpg)](https://example.com)</code>	Wrap image syntax in link syntax to make image clickable .
HTML image with sizing	<code></code>	• Use HTML <code></code> tag to control image dimensions • Markdown has no native sizing syntax.
Relative path image	<code>![Alt](./assets/img.png)</code>	• Reference images using relative paths to the current file • preferred for repository images.

TABLE 7
Code

Showing code is one of Markdown's most-used jobs. Single backticks handle inline snippets, while fenced blocks with triple backticks wrap whole listings — and adding a language identifier after the opening fence unlocks syntax highlighting. The older indented-block style still works but fenced code is almost always the better choice.

Type	Example	Description
Inline code	<code>`code`</code>	Wrap text in single backticks <code>`</code> for inline code within text.
Inline code with backticks	<code>``code with `backtick```</code>	Use double backticks to include a literal backtick inside inline code.
Fenced code block	<code>
`code line 1`
`code line 2`
`</code>	• Wrap code in triple backticks <code>` `</code> or tildes <code>~~~`</code> • cleaner than indenting; supports syntax highlighting.
Syntax highlighting	<code>`python<br>`def hello():`<br>`print("Hello")`<br>`</code>	• Add language identifier after opening fence • enables syntax highlighting for that language.
Indented code block	<code>code line 1</code> <code>code line 2</code>	• Indent every line by 4 spaces or 1 tab to create a code block (legacy style) • prefer fenced).

TABLE 8

Blockquotes

A leading `>` turns a line into a quote, useful for citing sources or setting text apart. Blockquotes can span multiple paragraphs, nest several levels deep, and even contain other Markdown like headings and lists.

Technique	Example	Description
Basic blockquote	<code>> This is a quote.</code>	Start line with <code>></code> followed by a space to create a blockquote .
Multi-paragraph blockquote	<code>> First paragraph.</code> <code>></code> <code>> Second paragraph.</code>	Add <code>></code> on blank lines between paragraphs to keep them in the same blockquote.
Nested blockquote	<code>> Level 1</code> <code>>> Level 2</code>	Use additional <code>></code> symbols to create nested blockquotes .
Blockquote with other elements	<code>> ### Heading</code> <code>> - List item</code>	Blockquotes can contain headings, lists, code, and other Markdown elements .

TABLE 9

Horizontal Rules

A horizontal rule draws a divider line to separate sections of a document. Three or more hyphens, asterisks, or underscores on their own line all produce the same thematic break — pick whichever you find most readable in the raw source.

Syntax	Example	Description
Three hyphens	<code>---</code>	Use three or more hyphens <code>-</code> on a line by themselves to create a horizontal rule .
Three asterisks	<code>***</code>	Use three or more asterisks <code>*</code> for a horizontal divider .
Three underscores	<code>---</code>	Use three or more underscores <code>_</code> for a thematic break .

TABLE 10

Tables

Tables are a GFM extension built from pipes and hyphens, with a separator row defining the header. Colons in that separator control column alignment — left, center, or right — and an HTML entity lets you slip a literal pipe character into a cell without breaking the structure.

Element	Example	Description
Basic table	<code> H1 H2 </code> <code> --- --- </code> <code> A B </code>	- Use pipes <code> </code> to separate columns and hyphens <code>-</code> to create header row GFM extension.
Left alignment	<code> :--- </code>	Add colon <code>:</code> on the left side of hyphens in header row to left-align column.
Center alignment	<code> :---: </code>	Add colons <code>:</code> on both sides of hyphens to center-align column.
Right alignment	<code> ---: </code>	Add colon <code>:</code> on the right side of hyphens to right-align column.
Pipe in table cell	<code> A &#124; B </code>	Use HTML entity <code>
</code> to display a literal pipe character inside a table cell.

TABLE 11

Escaping Characters

Sometimes you want a character that Markdown treats as syntax to show up literally — an asterisk that isn't italics, or a backtick that isn't code. A backslash before the character escapes it, and wrapping symbols in backticks is an alternative that displays them verbatim.

Technique	Example	Description
Backslash escape	<code>*not italic*</code>	Use backslash <code>\`</code> before special characters to display them literally instead of formatting.
Escapable characters	<code>` ` ` * _ { } [] () # + - . ! </code> These ASCII punctuation characters can be escaped with a backslash.	
Inline code for symbols	<code>`*`</code>	Wrap symbols in backticks to display them literally without escaping .

TABLE 12

HTML Embedding

When Markdown alone can't do what you need, you can drop raw HTML right into the document. This unlocks features with no native syntax — styled spans, collapsible `<details>` sections, and hidden comments — though block-level HTML needs blank lines around it to render correctly.

Technique	Example	Description
Inline HTML	This is <code><mark></code> highlighted <code></mark></code> text.	• Insert HTML tags directly into Markdown • works for features Markdown doesn't support natively.
HTML block	<code><div style="color: red;"></code> Red text <code></div></code>	• Use block-level HTML elements for advanced formatting • must be separated by blank lines.
Collapsible section	<code><details></code> <code><summary></code> Toggle <code></summary></code> Hidden content <code></details></code>	• Use <code><details></code> and <code><summary></code> HTML elements for collapsible sections • add blank lines before/after Markdown inside.
Comments	<code><!-- This is a comment --></code>	Use HTML comment syntax <code><!-- --></code> to add hidden notes that won't appear in output.

TABLE 13

YAML Front Matter

Front matter is a YAML block fenced by triple dashes at the very top of a file, carrying metadata about the document rather than its content. Static site generators and tools like Pandoc, Jekyll, and Hugo read these fields — title, author, date, tags — to drive page titles, exports, and site behavior, and you can add arbitrary custom keys for your own tooling.

Element	Example	Description
Front matter block	<code>---</code> title: My Document author: Jane Doe <code>---</code>	• Place YAML block at the very start of a file between triple dashes <code>---</code> • provides document-level metadata consumed by tools like Pandoc, Jekyll, Hugo.
title field	title: "My Post Title"	Sets the document title used in exports, page <code><title></code> , and table-of-contents generation.
author field	author: - Jane Doe - John Smith	• Specifies document authors • accepts a string or list • used in PDF/DOCX title pages via Pandoc.

Element	Example	Description
date field	date: 2026-04-28	- Sets the document date - used in rendered output such as PDF/DOCX and by static site generators.
tags / keywords	tags: [markdown, docs]	- Specifies searchable tags or keywords - recognized by Obsidian, Zettlr, and many static site generators.
lang field	lang: en-US	Sets document locale for Pandoc exports — controls quotation marks, citation style, and punctuation.
custom fields	draft: true weight: 10	- Any arbitrary key-value pair - consumed by the site generator or tooling that processes the file.

TABLE 14

Extended Syntax — Footnotes

Footnotes let you attach a reference marker in your text to a note that renders at the bottom of the page — invaluable for citations and asides in long-form writing. You place the `[^id]` marker inline and define its content separately, using either numbers or word labels, and a footnote can even span multiple indented paragraphs.

Element	Example	Description
Footnote reference	Here is a footnote[^1].	Add <code>[^number]</code> or <code>[^label]</code> to create a superscript footnote reference .
Footnote definition	[^1]: Footnote content.	Define footnote content anywhere in document using <code>[^number]</code> : followed by text - renders at bottom.
Named footnote	Here[^note]. [^note]: Named ref.	- Use a word label instead of a number - still renders as sequential number in output.
Multi-paragraph footnote	[^1]: First paragraph. Second paragraph.	Indent continuation paragraphs by 4 spaces to include multiple paragraphs in a footnote.

TABLE 15

Extended Syntax — Definition Lists

Definition lists pair a term with one or more definitions — the format you'd use for a glossary. The definition line starts with a colon, and a single term can carry several definitions. It's an extended-syntax feature, so not every parser supports it.

Element	Example	Description
Definition list	Term : Definition	- Create term-definition pairs by starting definition line with <code>:</code> followed by spaces - extended syntax, not in CommonMark.
Multiple definitions	Term : Definition 1 : Definition 2	A single term can have multiple definitions listed on separate lines.

TABLE 16

Extended Syntax — Abbreviations

Define an abbreviation once and every occurrence of it in the document gets a hover tooltip spelling out the full term — handy for keeping acronym-heavy technical docs readable. It's an extended-syntax feature supported by parsers like Python-Markdown.

Technique	Example	Description
Abbreviation definition	<code>*[HTML]: Hyper Text Markup Language</code>	- Define abbreviations using <code>*[abbr]: definition</code> - creates tooltip on hover showing full text wherever that abbreviation appears.

TABLE 17

Extended Syntax — Emoji

There are two ways to get emoji into Markdown: type a shortcode like `:rocket:` that the platform converts, or paste the actual Unicode character. Shortcodes are convenient but their names vary between platforms, whereas pasted Unicode emoji work everywhere.

Method	Example	Description
Emoji shortcode	<code>:smile: +1: :rocket:</code>	- Type emoji names between colons <code>::</code> to insert emojis shortcode names vary by platform.
Unicode emoji	 +	- Copy and paste actual emoji characters directly into Markdown - works universally across platforms.

TABLE 18

Math Expressions

Many platforms now render LaTeX math inside Markdown via MathJax or KaTeX — single dollar signs for inline expressions, double for centered display blocks. The rest of the entries are a quick LaTeX primer for the notation you'll reach for most: fractions, roots, summations and integrals, and Greek letters.

Syntax	Example	Description
Inline math	<code>\$E = mc^2\$</code>	Wrap expression in single dollar signs <code>\$...\$</code> for inline math rendered by MathJax or KaTeX.
Display math (block)	<code>\$\$\sum_{k=1}^n a_k\$\$</code>	Wrap expression in double dollar signs <code>\$\$...\$\$</code> on its own line for centered block math .
Code-fence math block	<code>`math<br>`\int_0^1 x^2 dx`<br>`</code>	GitHub also supports a <code>`math`</code> fenced block as an alternative to <code>\$\$**</code> for display math.
Inline math (backtick delimiter)	<code>\$`\sqrt{3x-1}`\$</code>	GitHub alternate inline syntax using <code>\$`...`\$</code> to avoid conflicts with dollar-sign currency .
Fractions	<code>`\${\frac{a}{b}}\$</code>	Use <code>\frac{numerator}{denominator}</code> for fraction notation .
Square root	<code>`\${\sqrt{x^2 + y^2}}\$</code>	- Use <code>\sqrt{expr}</code> for square roots <code>\sqrt[n]{expr}</code> for nth roots.
Summation / integral	<code>`\${\sum_{i=1}^n x_i}\$</code>	Use <code>\sum</code> , <code>\int</code> , <code>\prod</code> with subscript/superscript bounds for series and integrals.
Greek letters	<code>`\${\alpha \beta \gamma \pi}\$</code>	LaTeX commands <code>\alpha</code> , <code>\beta</code> , <code>\Gamma</code> , <code>\pi</code> , etc. render Greek letter symbols .

TABLE 19

Mermaid Diagrams

Mermaid lets you describe diagrams as plain text inside a fenced code block, and platforms like GitHub, GitLab, and Obsidian render them as real graphics. It's a remarkably versatile toolkit — the diagram types here range from flowcharts and sequence diagrams to Gantt charts, class and ER diagrams, pie charts, and state machines.

Type	Example	Description
Flowchart	<code>` mermaid <br>`flowchart TD`<br>` A[Start] --> B{Yes?}`<br> `</code>	• Declare <code>flowchart TD</code> (top-down) or <code>LR</code> (left-right) • rendered in GitHub, GitLab, VS Code, Obsidian, and more.
Sequence diagram	<code>` mermaid <br>`sequenceDiagram`<br>` Alice->>Bob: Hello`<br> `</code>	• Shows message flow between actors • uses <code>->></code> for arrows, <code>Note over</code> for annotations.
Gantt chart	<code>` mermaid <br>`gantt`<br>` section Phase1`<br>` Task :a1, 2024-01-01, 7d`<br> `</code>	Renders project timeline with tasks, sections, and dependencies.
Class diagram	<code>` mermaid <br>`classDiagram`<br>` Animal < -- Dog`<br> `</code>	Models OOP class relationships with inheritance, composition, and interfaces.
Entity relationship diagram	<code>` mermaid <br>`erDiagram`<br>` CUSTOMER --o{ ORDER : places`<br> `</code>	Defines database entity relationships using ERD notation with cardinality symbols.
Pie chart	<code>` mermaid <br>`pie title Pets`<br>` "Dogs" : 40`<br>` "Cats" : 60`<br> `</code>	Renders a labeled pie chart from simple key-value pairs.
State diagram	<code>` mermaid <br>`stateDiagram-v2`<br>` Idle --> Active : click`<br> `</code>	Models finite state machines with states, transitions, and fork/join nodes.

TABLE 20

GitHub Flavored Markdown (GFM) Extensions

These are GitHub-specific niceties that only work within GitHub itself. Typing `@username` pings a person, `#123` links to an issue, and a pasted commit SHA becomes a link — small touches that make conversations in issues and PRs flow. Note that GFM also strips certain raw HTML tags for security.

Feature	Example	Description
Username mentions	<code>@username</code>	• Type <code>@username</code> to mention a GitHub user or team • triggers a notification and creates a profile link.
Issue references	<code>#123</code>	Type <code>#</code> followed by issue number to link to GitHub issues or pull requests.
Color model display	<code>`#0969DA` `rgb(9,105,218)`</code>	• Backtick-wrapped hex, RGB, or HSL color values render a color swatch preview • only in issues, PRs, and discussions.
Commit SHA references	<code>16c999e8c71134401a78d4d46435517b2271d6ac</code>	Paste full commit SHA to auto-create a link to that commit.
Disallowed raw HTML	<code>Filters <title> <script> <style> etc.</code>	• GFM restricts certain HTML tags for security • they're rendered as plain text.

TABLE 21

GitHub Alerts (Callouts)

Alerts are colored callout boxes that draw the eye to something important. Built on blockquote syntax with a `[!TYPE]` marker, the five flavors each carry their own color and tone — from a neutral blue NOTE up to a red CAUTION warning of real risk — so readers can gauge severity at a glance.

Type	Example	Description
NOTE alert	<pre>> [!NOTE] > Useful information.</pre>	- Displays a blue info box - use for general information users should know.
TIP alert	<pre>> [!TIP] > Helpful advice.</pre>	- Displays a green tip box - use for optional advice that helps users do things better.
IMPORTANT alert	<pre>> [!IMPORTANT] > Key information.</pre>	- Displays a purple box - use for information critical to achieving a goal.
WARNING alert	<pre>> [!WARNING] > Urgent info.</pre>	- Displays a yellow/orange box - use for urgent information needing immediate attention.
CAUTION alert	<pre>> [!CAUTION] > Risky action.</pre>	- Displays a red box - advises about risks or negative outcomes of certain actions.

TABLE 22

Markdown Variants and Flavors

There's no single Markdown — the original spec left gaps, and different communities filled them in different ways. CommonMark is the unambiguous baseline most tools now follow, GFM is the dominant developer dialect, and the rest (Pandoc, MultiMarkdown, MDX, and others) each add features for academic writing, document conversion, or interactive React components.

Variant	Example	Description
CommonMark	Standard specification	Unambiguous Markdown specification resolving inconsistencies in original Markdown - widely adopted as baseline by most tools.
GitHub Flavored Markdown	GFM	- GitHub's extension adding tables, task lists, strikethrough, autolinks, alerts, math, and Mermaid - most popular developer flavor.
GitLab Flavored Markdown	GLFM	GitLab's superset of GFM adding math, diagrams, color chips, multiline blockquotes , and GitLab-specific references.
Markdown Extra	PHP Markdown Extra	Extends Markdown with footnotes, definition lists, tables, fenced code blocks, and abbreviations .
Pandoc Markdown	Pandoc flavor	Pandoc's extensive extension set including superscript, subscript, LaTeX math, YAML metadata blocks, and citations.
MultiMarkdown	MMD	Adds metadata, tables, footnotes, citations, math for academic and long-form writing.
MDX	Markdown + JSX	- Combines Markdown with JSX/React components - used in Next.js, Docusaurus, and Astro for interactive documentation.

TABLE 23

Best Practices

Markdown that renders correctly isn't always Markdown that's pleasant to maintain. These habits — blank lines around headings, consistent list markers, fenced code over indented, alt text on every image, and semantic line breaks for cleaner diffs — keep your source readable and portable across the widest range of parsers.

Practice	Example	Description
Blank lines around headings	<pre>text # Heading text</pre>	Put blank lines before and after headings for maximum compatibility and readability.
Consistent list markers	Use <code>-</code> consistently	Stick to one bullet character (<code>-</code> , <code>*</code> , or <code>+</code>) throughout a document for unordered lists.
Fenced code over indented	Use <code>`</code> instead of indents	Prefer fenced code blocks with triple backticks; clearer and supports syntax highlighting.
Reference links for readability	<code>[text][ref]</code> at end	Use reference-style links when text has many links; keeps source readable.
Alt text for images	<code>![Descriptive alt text](img.jpg)</code>	Always provide meaningful alt text for images; critical for accessibility and SEO.
Semantic line breaks	Break at sentence/clause	Breaking lines at sentence or clause boundaries improves version control diffs.
Relative links in repos	<code>[Docs](./docs/guide.md)</code>	Use relative links for files within a repository so links work across branches and forks.
Avoid hard wrapping	Let editors wrap	Let text editors handle soft wrapping ; hard wrapping at arbitrary column widths creates maintenance issues.

TABLE 24

Common Pitfalls and Gotchas

The subtle traps that make Markdown "not render right" — and they catch experienced writers too. A missing blank line before a list, too-shallow nested indentation, underscores triggering accidental italics inside `snake_case` , blank lines breaking a table, or a dollar sign mistaken for math: knowing these failure modes saves a lot of confused debugging.

Issue	Example	Description
Missing blank line before list	<pre>text - list</pre> won't render	Lists require a blank line before them when following a paragraph in many parsers.
Incorrect nested list indentation	<pre>- Item - Wrong</pre>	- Nested lists need 4 spaces or 1 tab indentation 1–2 spaces may silently fail in strict parsers.
Underscore in words	<code>snake_case_variable</code>	- Underscores within words can trigger unintended italics - use asterisks or code formatting instead.
Trailing spaces for line breaks	Not visible in editors	Two trailing spaces are invisible ; consider using backslash <code>\</code> or <code>`</code> for clarity.
Ordered list auto-numbering	<pre>1. First 1. Second</pre> renders as 1, 2	- Markdown auto-corrects list numbers - using <code>1.</code> for all items is valid but explicit numbering is clearer.
Inconsistent empty lines in tables	Tables break with empty lines	- Table rows must be consecutive - blank lines terminate the table.
Math dollar sign conflict	<code>\$50 items</code> may trigger math	- Dollar signs used as currency can conflict with inline math delimiters - escape with <code>\\$50</code> or use <code>\${50</code> .

Issue	Example	Description
HTML in list items	Requires careful spacing	HTML elements in lists need proper indentation and blank lines or they break list structure.
Markdown inside HTML blocks	<code><div>**bold**</div></code> fails	Markdown formatting does not process inside HTML block elements — add blank lines around Markdown content within HTML.

TABLE 25

Advanced Techniques

Once you're comfortable with the basics, these techniques squeeze more out of the syntax — collapsed reference links, definitions placed anywhere in the file, lazy blockquote continuation, hand-built tables of contents from heading anchors, and Obsidian-style wikilinks. They're the touches that separate workmanlike Markdown from genuinely polished documents.

Technique	Example	Description
Nested formatting	<code>***bold and italic***</code>	Combine multiple emphasis markers for layered formatting effects.
Collapsed reference links	<code>[GitHub] []</code> <code>[GitHub]:</code> <code>https://github.com</code>	• Omit reference label when link text matches reference • shorthand syntax.
Link reference definitions anywhere	<code>[text][ref]</code> <code>[ref]: url</code> at bottom	• Reference definitions can be placed anywhere in document • commonly at end for organization.
Blockquote continuation	<code>> Line 1 continues</code> <code>on this line</code>	Markdown allows lazy continuation of blockquotes without <code>></code> on each wrapped line.
Mixing HTML with Markdown	<code><div></code> <code>**Markdown** works here</code> <code></div></code>	Markdown inside HTML blocks requires blank lines around the Markdown content.
Raw URLs in angle brackets	<code><https://example.com></code>	Angle brackets ensure URLs with special chars are recognized as links.
Table of contents via anchor links	<code>[Intro](#introduction)</code>	• Manually create a TOC using heading anchors • GitHub/GitLab auto-generate heading IDs from heading text.
Wikilinks (Obsidian-style)	<code>[[Note Name]]</code>	Obsidian and some platforms support double-bracket internal links to other notes by filename.

TABLE 26

Editor and Tool Support

Markdown's reach comes from its ecosystem. This roundup spans the tools you'll actually write and ship with — VS Code and Typora for editing, Obsidian for linked notes, Pandoc for converting to anything, and static site generators like Jekyll, Hugo, and Quarto for publishing — so you can match the right tool to whether you're taking notes, building docs, or producing scientific output.

Tool	Example	Description
VS Code Markdown Preview	Built-in preview	• Side-by-side preview with syntax highlighting • extensive extension ecosystem including Mermaid, math, and linting.
Obsidian	Note-taking app	Knowledge base tool with bidirectional wikilinks, graph view, callouts, math, and Markdown-first approach.
Typora	WYSIWYG editor	• Live preview editor that hides Markdown syntax while typing • seamless WYSIWYG experience.
Pandoc	Document converter	Universal converter supporting Markdown to/from dozens of formats including PDF, DOCX, HTML, and EPUB.

Tool	Example	Description
Material for MkDocs	Documentation site	- Documentation theme with admonitions, tabs, grids, math, and Mermaid support - widely used for open-source project docs.
HackMD / CodiMD	Collaborative editor	Real-time collaborative Markdown editing with math, Mermaid, presentation mode, and multi-user support.
Zettlr	Research writing	Academic Markdown editor with YAML front matter, Pandoc citations, Zotero integration .
Jekyll	Static site generator	Blog-aware static site generator using Markdown for content - powers GitHub Pages.
Hugo	Fast static generator	Extremely fast static site generator with Markdown support, Mermaid, math, and rich theming.
Quarto	Scientific publishing	- Publishing system built on Pandoc supporting executable code, math, Mermaid, and cross-references - used in data science and academia.

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